The Importance of Olympia to Ancient Greece

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Although Olympia is best known for hosting the Olympic Games, the stadium was just one part of the complex. Olympia was a sanctuary dedicated to Zeus, featuring temples, altars, and offerings. Religion gave meaning to the Games and brought representatives of different city-states to a common, holy place.

Olympia: History and Architectural Features

Located near where the Alpheios and Kladeos rivers meet in Elis in the western Peloponnese, Olympia was a place of worship by the tenth century BCE, earlier than any known list of Olympic victors. The sacred area, known as the *Altis*, became connected with Zeus and the hero Pelops (Sinn, 1996/2000). One of the first major buildings on the site was the Temple of Hera, built around 600 BCE (Barringer, 2021).

Libon of Elis (active in the fifth century BCE; birth and death dates unknown) designed the Doric Temple of Zeus, and it was built between about 470 and 456 BCE. It had six columns across the front and thirteen along the sides. White stucco covered the local limestone to imitate marble. The sculptures depicted traditional stories: Pelops before his chariot race on the east pediment, the mythic struggle between the Lapiths and Centaurs on the west, and the labors of Heracles on the metopes (Barringer, 2021). These scenes reflected athletic contests and the culture of winning.

The *Altis* also contained the Pelopion, altars, treasuries, and votive statues. The nearby gymnasium and *palaestra* served as places for athletic training. The stadium stood east of the sacred area, bringing together sport and rituals. Philip II of Macedon (382-336 BCE) began building the round Ionic Philippeion after his victory at Chaeronea in 338 BCE. It held statues of his family (Barringer, 2021).

Statue of Zeus and Phidias

The famous Statue of Zeus added to the temple's importance. The Athenian sculptor Phidias (c. 490-c. 430 BCE) made it in the later fifth century BCE. Phidias built the figure on a wooden frame, using ivory for the skin and gold for the clothes (Lapatin, 2001). The statue showed Zeus seated on a richly decorated throne with Nike in one hand and an eagle-topped scepter in the other. Pausanias (c. 110-c. 180 CE) later described the throne's ebony, gemstones, painted figures, gold, and ivory (Pausanias, ca. second century CE/1926, 5.11.1-2). Although seated, the statue was more than twelve meters high and became one of the Seven Wonders of the Ancient World.

Archaeological evidence also helps to tell the story. In the 1950s, German archaeologists found the workshop of Phidias west of the temple. The workshop was as large as the temple's inner chamber and contained ivory pieces, tools, and molds. One cup had Phidias's name scratched into it (Lapatin, 2001). These finds show the work needed to create the statue.

Importance of the Olympic Games

The traditional list of Olympic victors begins in 776 BCE. The festival honored Zeus and took place at four-year intervals. Athletes took an oath and performed sacrifices before competing. Events included footraces, wrestling, boxing, the pentathlon, *pankration*, and chariot racing (Miller, 2004). Winners received an olive wreath at Olympia, although their home cities might later reward them with money or other privileges.

While the Greek city-states often fought each other, they followed common rules and a common schedule at Olympia. A sacred truce allowed athletes and spectators to travel safely to the festival, although it did not end all wars (Kyle, 2007). City-states made dedications, and rulers erected monuments before the assembled people. Thus, Olympia connected Greek cities

while allowing them to compete for prestige. However, participation was restricted, especially in the Greek period. Women could win as chariot owners but could not compete as athletes (Miller, 2004).

Conclusion

The Temple and the Statue of Zeus show the sacred aspect of the Games, while the stadium shows how worship was connected to public competition. Olympia gave several city-states a common festival and a place to demonstrate their greatness. It provided a reason for the Greek polities to gather and functioned as a sanctuary for more than a thousand years. The workshop of Phidias and the ruined temples still explain why ancient visitors saw Olympia as more than an athletic area.

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